My PhD Backwards Calendar

Political Science PhD - Penn State - Fall 2026 to Summer 2031

This is a plan for myself, not a strict promise. I want to use it to remember what I am trying to do each year, but I know some things will take longer and some opportunities will come up unexpectedly. I should check the department and dual-title requirements as I go, especially for exams and deadlines. Publication and job outcomes also depend on people outside of me, so I should treat those as goals to work toward, not things that define whether I am doing well.

2026-2027 | First Year

This year I want to get used to the program and build a good base. I will apply for the PiCP research grant, revise my Sabancı MA thesis into a journal paper, and work on making it ready to submit by the end of the year. I will also improve the foreign occupation project: the theory, the identification strategy, and the empirical design all need more work. I want to build a GitHub portfolio with my research, reproducible data work, methods projects, and personal software projects. At the same time, I need to finish my first-year classes, get better at statistics and methods, and prepare for the written qualifying exam in Summer 2027. Outside school, I want to settle into life in the United States, keep a reasonable work-life balance, have at least one regular hobby, and start saving and investing consistently so I can build an emergency fund.

2027-2028 | Second Year

I will complete the oral qualifying exam in Fall 2027 and focus my classes on comparative politics, causal inference, computational methods, and useful SoDA courses. I want to aim for an R&R; from a journal, but I know that depends on editors and reviewers as well as my own work. I will start the Penn State MA thesis by settling on the question, reading the literature properly, finding the data, making a realistic design, talking to faculty, and setting a timeline. My goal is to defend it by Spring 2028. If funding and timing work out, I also want to do fieldwork or archival work for the foreign occupation project. I will try to present at a conference, ideally go to one abroad, help with the Sabancı Turkish Politics Lab, build academic connections in the United States, Europe, and Türkiye, and look for a short RAship or a faculty collaboration. If my finances allow it, I also want to buy a car.

2028-2029 | Third Year

I want to finish the remaining Political Science and Social Data Analytics requirements and complete the third-year research project. The main goal is to put together and defend a dissertation proposal and complete the oral comprehensive exam by Spring 2029. I would like to publish a sole-authored paper in a top journal, but this is a stretch goal and I should not treat it as a minimum requirement. I will turn the Penn State MA thesis into a paper, keep learning advanced methods and computational tools, and keep adding useful work to my GitHub portfolio. I also want to look for RAships and collaborations that help my dissertation and work out the main idea that connects my older projects to the dissertation.

2029-2030 | Fourth Year

I want to bring my projects together under one clear theme that supports the dissertation. I will try to have at least three projects that are close to being ready for publication, including an original data paper if that makes sense. I will keep papers under review or in revision and aim for a top-journal publication, while remembering that publication timing is not fully in my control. The main work is collecting the dissertation data, doing the analysis, and writing real chapters. By this point I want to have attended or presented at five conferences in total, including two abroad if possible. I will keep building connections in the United States, Europe, and Türkiye, look for collaborations or funded projects, and try to teach my own course in comparative politics, political economy, or quantitative methods. I also need to start getting ready for the job market: choose a job-market paper, update my CV, write research and teaching statements, build a teaching portfolio, talk to potential referees, keep the website up to date, and learn about private-sector research and data-science options too.

2030-2031 | Fifth Year

My first priority is to finish and improve the dissertation so that it is ready to defend before I graduate. By Summer 2030, I want to have the important job-market things in place: a good job-market paper, a current CV, a research statement, a teaching statement and portfolio, this website, confirmed referees, a list of departments and postdocs to apply to, and time to practice job talks and interviews. I will apply to tenure-track jobs and postdocs in the United States, Europe, and Türkiye, but I will also look at data science, computational social science, and applied research jobs. I want to attend at least fifteen job talks so I understand both academic and private-sector paths better. I will keep meeting people at conferences and workshops, try to teach independently if I have not done that yet, and keep submitting papers without letting them stop me from finishing the dissertation. I also want to save enough money for moving and starting the next job.

2031 | Graduation and What Comes Next

I want to defend and submit the dissertation as early as I can, ideally in Spring or Summer 2031. I hope to start a tenure-track job in Fall 2031, preferably in the United States or Europe, but I will stay open to good options in Türkiye too. If the right tenure-track job is not there, I will seriously consider a strong postdoc or a research-focused private-sector job. I will keep turning dissertation chapters into articles, build a research agenda that I can carry forward on my own, and make sure I have enough savings for relocation, housing deposits, and the first months in a new place.

Two things I should keep in mind: the Spring 2028 MA defense, Spring 2029 comprehensive exam, and Summer 2030 job-market preparation depend on each other, so a delay in one may move the next ones. The R&R; goal in 2027-2028 and the sole-authored top-journal paper in 2028-2029 are stretch goals, not tests of whether I am making good progress.

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